A Gaggle of Saints

By Neil LaBute

Silence . . . a young, attractive couple stand apart from one another, dressed in the evening fashion.

JOHN: **(Pg 35-36)** So, okay, there was this big bash in the city. That's what we came down for. This get-together. Couple churches together, I think, and meeting in the city. Ballroom over at the plaza.

SUE: People from high school were going. Seniors now, mostly.

JOHN: We're juniors up at B.C., so, like, there's still lots of guys we know, who we're still in touch with. Friends, you know . . . **(Pg 38)** It just sounded really great, weekend back in New York. Stop in, maybe, say "hi" to the folks . . .

SUE: **(Pg 39)** We all thought we could go down together. One car. Everybody wanted to, gonna be in the city at this hotel, live band and everything. . .

INTRODUCTION

Some of the most frightening moments in life are when you realize that a person you love and trust has been putting up a front the whole time: The husband that comes out of the closet. Grandparents who get divorced after being together forever. Discovering you had siblings you didn't know about. These things happen to "normal" people all the time. People are capable of anything.

In Gaggle of Saints, Neil LaBute introduces us to John and Sue, two Mormon sweethearts who tell the story of attending a formal dance in New York City. But it's what happens after the dance in Central Park that makes the unexpected frightening.

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JOHN: **(Pg 39-40)** And so six of us, a girl that's going out with this David from my fraternity, Karen's her name; I think. . . she was coming too cause she knew the city pretty well,

SUE: David said he'd drive and we're all picked up at three in the afternoon, Saturday.

JOHN: I'm rushing around, fighting for tuxedos, ten minutes to six, Friday afternoon! *(beat)* I ended up with a Perry Ellis. Finally. A size big, but I got one. . . looks okay, doesn't it?

SUE: It looked good on him. . .I had to put a safety pin in the vest, in the back of it, but it was really

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nice when he had it on. I had this dress I'd been saving. . . all black taffeta.

JOHN: **(Pg 41-44)** Kind of a cutaway in the front, what's it called? "Scalloped," in the front and no back to it at all. *(beat)* She looked great . . .

SUE: This was going to be a great party *(pause)* I could feel it. It was our anniversary. . .

JOHN: Last minute got her a corsage. White blossoms. Don't know what kind, but they were white. I remember that. . .

SUE: The softest pink, it was . . . John thought it was white, but it was really just the lightest shade of pink. *(beat)* And you know? He pricked his finger, John did. As he pinned it on me, pricked his index finger. . .

JOHN: Stupid pin!

SUE: A spot of blood, just a drop on his shirt. . . in a weird way it excited me. The blood. *(beat)* I mean, the bright of his shirt . . . and then this splash of blood on his chest.

JOHN: Didn't get any on her dress. Felt good about that. . . wouldn't want to ruin her anniversary dress.

SUE: Four years. . .

JOHN: **(Pg 45)** Believe that? Four . . .since summer of our third year in high school. Wow. . .

SUE: **(Pg 53-56)** It was going to be great. A really good evening, I could feel it. . .

JOHN: And we walk arm in arm. Man, feels so nice to stroll past all these people, I mean, rich guys, girl like that on my arm! Made me feel strong, you know? Powerful.

SUE: We've got nowhere to go. . . nothing but possibilities. The party's not until later. . .

JOHN: David's girlfriend, "Karen," takes the lead at some point, walking us through the park. . . over by that one bridge, the big pond? Moon's smiling down and all, romance hanging over a night like this out of some storybook . . . I really do love this girl. That's the thing that's screaming out in my head right then. . .

SUE: He was holding my hand so tight. . .

JOHN: A perfect night. And then, off to our left, there's this, like, patch of woods near the path. Comes this rustling. . . I'm not scared but it's night . . .what else can you do, girls with you?

SUE: I thought it might be some teenagers. We all started to walk a bit faster . . .

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JOHN: And two middle-aged guys, L.L. Bean shirts, come out of the dark. Smiling. And I don't need a map to tell me what's been going on *(pause)* I don't.

SUE: It was just two men. Walking along. . . no big deal.

JOHN: They were off in the park alone. And these smiles. One dude looks like my father, a little, it's dark but he had that look, right, that settled, satisfied sort of . . . anyway, off they head, arms linked together and nothing we say ever going to change what they are. *(pause)* [We] Dance all night . . .

SUE: I haven't danced like that in a long time. . .

JOHN: I'm telling you, I can't get that picture out of my head. Those smiles. I can't do it. . . *(beat)* but the party is great. It really is. . .

SUE: **(Pg 57-58)** I'd never been to the plaza before, I mean, past it, shopping and whatever, with my mom, but never to it. It was tremendous! So much glass. **(Pg 56)** They'd done the whole room in blues and golds with these great moons, these golden crescents handing above us.

JOHN: Like smiles . . .

SUE: **(Pg 58)** High white walls. . . *(beat)* the whole thing, though. . . the trip, dance and all. . .made me sleepy.

JOHN: Sue went upstairs to our room with Karen and Tim's girlfriend, Patrice . . . Said they wanted to take a quick nap, then we'd go get a bite. This was, like, maybe, one-thirty. . .

SUE: **(Pg 59)** I'm not sure what time it was . . .

JOHN: We hung out downstairs a bit, talked to some guys from home. . .David, Tim, and me. I was bored. You know. . .so I suggested a walk. "Let's head over to the park." We shoot over into Central Park, the 59th Street entrance. . . looking around, talking. Really dark in there. Only lights coming from the buildings, way off. Kind of exciting. . .

SUE: I thought I looked up at two, or two-fifteen. . . but I'm not sure. 'cause I kept sleeping. . .

JOHN: . . .and then I saw 'em. Both of them. Those guys. . . **(Pg 60-64)** They were saying "goodnight. . ." well, not ***saying*** it exactly. But kissing. Two grown men, standing in this public park in the middle of New York and kissing like something out of a Clark gable film. Arms around each other, and nothing else in the world matters to these two. . . hands all where they

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shouldn't be. I mean, come on, I know the scriptures, know 'em pretty well, and this is wrong. *(beat)* You know, you read about it, right, and you live with it. Don't love it; don't condone it for the world. Still,live and let live, whatever. But this is ***flaunting*** it. I mean, we're in town ***one*** night, that's all, ***one***. . . and we got 'a witness this? *(pause)*

Men old enough to be our fathers clutching at one another like Romeo and Juliet! *(beat)* I start to feel sick, I mean it, nauseous. Then a last peck on the cheek and one disappears down a trail, headed for the west side. He's gone. The other one glances around, taking in the night, I guess, big smile up at the moon. . . and he strolls over to this "men's room." 50 yards off. Concrete building, with the steps down into it. Whistling while he goes. . . he was ***whistling***. I don't even stop to think this through but motion the guys to follow me.

I told the guys to hold off. Wait for me to flush him out, make sure no one wanders by. Our friend's legs, I spot, patiently sitting in a stall. Not a care in this world. I slip into the stall next to his, start fumbling with my belt; and like clockwork, this guy's hand comes up under my side of the partition. Pink fingers, wiggling up at me, imploring.

I notice this thin gold band on his little finger, catching the light. *(beat)* Two minutes later we're standing near the mirrors and sizing each other up. Name's "Chet," he says, and I don't even bat an eyelash as he moves in, his lips playing across my cheek. I just smile at him. I see his shoulders relax.

Then I let out a whistle that sends him stumbling back. Tim and Dave appear in the doorway. Chet comes back from his fantasies, a flicker in his eyes, realizing no good can come from this. . . and starts babbling. Even got down on his knees and the pleading. Begging. *(beat)* Probably a VP at some bank and he's wetting himself like an infant.

My first shot catches him just under the eye and he slams into a sink. With so many of us hitting, tearing at him, it's hard to get off a clean punch but I know I connect a few more times. Tim kicking him long after he's blacked out. . . *(pause)*

And then it's silence. Not a sound. And then, I'm leaning down, pulling that ring off his pinkie.

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(beat) I told you I noticed it. . . And that's how we leave him. . . *pause.* We all start, giggling, can't catch our breath we find it all so funny. We slip out, one by one, whooping it up like Indians.

SUE: The phone woke me up. . .

JOHN: We wanted to take the girls out to breakfast. Say they'll be down in fifteen minutes. . . *(pause)* We waited outside. Dave's walking around on the curb, talking to himself, and Tim pulls me aside. Wants to why I touched the guy. Let him kiss me. He'd glanced inside and seen it. But I didn't know, didn't have an answer. Isn't that strange?

SUE: (Pg 65-67) It was so quiet in the lobby as we were leaving. I started tip-toeing out. Isn't that funny? We met in front of the hotel, and I saw John's face. All cut up like he'd fallen. [He said he was] racing along the fountain out front, balancing on it, and slipped. Scraped himself up and blood on everything. *(beat)* Silly games. . . *(pause)* I was eating my French toast, when I notice this glint in my water glass. A spark of light. *(beat)* John'd slipped a ring in it! A beautiful gold thing. . . I loved him so much at that moment.

JOHN: Happy anniversary

SUE: It was a little big, but fit pretty well. Had this wonderful leaf pattern, all the way around. . . I kissed him there, in front of everybody, and he blushed a bit. We all laughed. I can't tell you what a wonderful weekend we had. . .

JOHN: We did end up taking the Amtrak back up. . . just Sue and myself.

SUE: It was my idea. . .the train. On the way back – I shouldn't even bring this up – a fight broke out. Well, not really a fight but this argument between a man and his girlfriend. A lot of yelling. She stand ups and starts pulling on her coach and this guy, I mean, just backhands her.

JOHN: (Pg 68) Knocked her up against the window, really hard. He'd given her a bloody nose.

SUE: I could feel John tense up, but the couple was kind of dirty-looking and they seemed like, you know . . . ***those*** kind of people. So I whispered to John to "let it go" *(beat)* and you know what? He didn't so much bat an eyelash. Just kept holding my hand and playing with the ring on my finger. That made me so happy . . .

JOHN: (Pg 69) And finally, as we tumbled along toward Massachusetts, I could feel Sue fall asleep

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against my shoulder. All warm. Protected. But not me. . .I couldn't drift off. So I sat up, watching the lights dance by, the moon grinning down. And you know, I started whistling to myself. I did. . .

SUE: I was asleep there on john's arm, but I'd swear I could hear music. . .

JOHN: Not loud, I mean, don't even recall the tune. But I was whistling. . .

SUE: **(Pg 70)** . . .this beautiful music as I was sleeping. Like the sound of angels calling us home. . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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